

For each city, I'll research and provide (copy/paste style, one city at a time):

1. **State statute(s)** governing vague or insufficient public records requests.
2. **City ordinance or written policy** (if one exists).
3. **Whether the request must reasonably identify the records.**
4. **Whether the agency may or must request clarification.**
5. **Whether the statutory response clock:**
 - pauses,
 - restarts,
 - continues running,
 - or is silent.
6. **Whether the agency is required to attempt a search before requesting clarification.**
7. **Whether follow-up attempts are required** (email, phone, second notice, etc.).
8. **What happens if the requestor never responds**, including:
 - automatic closure,
 - administrative closure,
 - abandonment,
 - denial,
 - no explicit rule.
9. **Whether the request can later be reopened** or requires a new request.
10. **Relevant Attorney General opinions or court decisions**, if any.
11. **Practical implications for workflow software**, including configurable rules you could implement.

The output for each city will look something like:

Birmingham, Alabama

Governing Law

- Ala. Code § 36-12-43
- Ala. Code § 36-12-44
- City of Birmingham Public Records Procedures

Must reasonably identify records?

Yes.

The statute expressly states that a public officer is not obligated to respond to a request that is:

- vague
- ambiguous
- overly broad
- unreasonable in scope.

Clarification permitted?

Yes.

The public officer may request clarification or additional information.

Clock pauses?

Yes—expressly by statute.

Section 36-12-44(g) provides that if clarification or additional information is requested, **all statutory timelines are tolled and restart upon receipt of the clarification as though the requester had submitted a new request.**

Agency required to search first?

No express requirement.

The statute allows the agency to determine that a request is too vague before conducting a full search.

Follow-up requirements

No statutory requirement for multiple contacts.

One reasonable clarification request appears sufficient.

If requestor never responds

The statute does not establish a mandatory abandonment period.

The request simply remains unprocessable because it is not a proper request.

Practical workflow recommendation

- Workflow state: **Pending Clarification**
- Pause statutory clock: **Yes**
- Restart statutory clock: **Yes (new start date upon clarification)**
- Allow configurable administrative closure after X days with no response
- Optional reminder notices (not legally required)

That level of detail is exactly what I think will be most useful when you translate the legal rules into configurable workflow behavior.

One suggestion

Since you've now asked me to research **11 cities** on this specific topic, I'd actually recommend expanding the scope slightly. Rather than organizing primarily by city, I can organize by **city within its governing state law**, because in most cases the controlling rules come from the state statute or attorney general guidance, with city policies filling in operational details.

That approach avoids repeating identical state-law discussions when you later ask about additional cities in the same state, and it will build into a reusable reference for your configuration engine.

I can also add a final matrix like this:

City	Clarification Allowed	Clock Pauses	Clock Restarts	Follow-up Required	Auto Close Allowed	New Request Required
Birmingham	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Configurable	No
Fayetteville	...	...	...	...	...	...
Tulsa	...	...	...	...	...	...

I think that comparison table will become one of the most valuable design references for your Optimum Q workflow engine.

if you want to expand, please do so

I'll expand it into a city-by-city/state-law reference and include a compact workflow-design matrix. I'll focus on primary sources first: statutes, city policies, AG/open-government guidance, and court guidance where useful.

Thought for 29s

Yes — I'd expand it this way for your configuration model.

Summary matrix

City	Governing law	Vague request rule	Clock effect	No response to clarification
Birmingham, AL	Alabama Open Records Act	Must identify record with reasonable specificity	Tolls and restarts after clarification	Not obligated to respond/process
Fayetteville, AR	Arkansas FOIA	Must be sufficiently specific for reasonable search	No express tolling rule found	Likely unprocessable until clarified
Tulsa, OK	Oklahoma Open Records Act + Tulsa EO	Must describe records with reasonable specificity	City policy allows clarification; no express statutory clock	May be denied if still not specific
Charlotte, NC	NC Public Records Act	No clear statutory vague-request denial rule	No fixed statutory clock; "promptly as possible"	Clarification is operational, not a formal toll
Atlanta, GA	Georgia Open Records Act	Clarification recommended for scope/timing	3-business-day response still applies	Treat as unresolved/insufficient unless clarified
Pittsburgh, PA	PA Right-to-Know Law	Must be sufficiently specific	5-business-day response clock; denial possible	Deny as insufficiently specific
Dearborn, MI	Michigan FOIA	Must describe record	5-business-day clock	Denial for insufficient

City	Governing law	Vague request rule	Clock effect	No response to clarification
		sufficiently to find it	for valid written request	description; requester may rewrite
Boise, ID	Idaho Public Records Act	Requests must specifically describe records/date range	3 working days for resident requests; no tolling rule found	Likely denied/incomplete if insufficient
Miami, FL	Florida Public Records Act	Cannot deny solely because broad; must clarify if unclear	No fixed clock; “reasonable time” / good-faith response	Agency should seek clarification; request may remain pending
Phoenix, AZ	Arizona Public Records Law	No precise statutory clock; prompt access standard	No specific toll rule found	Clarification is practical, not formal
San Francisco, CA	CPRA + Sunshine Ordinance	Must reasonably describe identifiable records; agency must assist	10-day determination still applies; possible 14-day extension	Clarification request does not clearly stop clock

Copy/paste city notes

Birmingham, Alabama

Alabama is the cleanest example. Alabama Code § 36-12-44 requires a request to identify the requested public record with reasonable specificity, and says a public officer is not obligated to respond to a request that is vague, ambiguous, overly broad, or unreasonable in scope. If the officer seeks clarification or additional information, the statutory timelines are tolled and restart upon receipt of clarification as though the requester submitted a new request.

The City of Birmingham’s public records page mirrors this rule: a valid request must be specific, seek an existing public record, and comply with the City’s written procedures. Birmingham’s form also states the City is not obligated to respond to vague, ambiguous, overly broad, or unreasonable requests.

Workflow setting: Pending Clarification = pause statutory clock; restart clock on clarification; allow administrative closure if no response after configurable days.

Fayetteville, Arkansas

Arkansas FOIA requires a request to be “sufficiently specific to enable the custodian to locate the records with reasonable effort.” The Arkansas FOIA handbook also requires written responses within the statutory period to written requests, including no-records, exemption, or wrong-custodian responses.

I did not find a Fayetteville-specific rule saying the clock expressly pauses when clarification is requested. Fayetteville points users to Arkansas FOIA resources and forms, but the key vague-description rule appears to come from state law.

Workflow setting: Pending Clarification = operational hold; statutory tolling not expressly established; require written clarification notice; optional denial/closure if no response.

Tulsa, Oklahoma

Tulsa has unusually useful local detail. Tulsa's executive order says requests must describe records with reasonable specificity, including enough detail for the custodian to be reasonably certain the records produced are responsive. Relevant factors include a general time frame, identifiable records rather than general information, and search terms that do not generate an unreasonably large number of records.

Tulsa's policy says the City Clerk or record custodian may ask the requester to clarify an unreasonably vague, open-ended, or otherwise insufficient request. If the request remains insufficient after clarification is requested, the request may be denied. For email, text, or similar electronic communications, the policy says if the request lacks a date range of six months or less and either originator, recipient, or general subject matter, the City will ask for clarification.

Workflow setting: Pending Clarification = required for vague/open-ended email/text searches; if no adequate clarification, allow denial.

Charlotte, North Carolina

North Carolina law is less mechanical. The NC Attorney General guide says agencies must furnish copies "as promptly as possible," and the law has no specific waiting period.

Charlotte's public records page describes the broad scope of North Carolina public records law and confirms that anyone can request public records for any reason. I did not find a Charlotte-specific clock-pause rule for vague requests.

Workflow setting: Pending Clarification = no statutory clock pause because there is no fixed statutory clock; track agency elapsed time and requester-wait time separately.

Atlanta, Georgia

Georgia requires agencies to respond within three business days. If records exist but are not immediately available, the response should describe the records and provide timing and cost estimates.

Georgia's AG guidance says written requests are a better practice for documenting and clarifying scope and timing. I did not find a Georgia rule saying a vague-request clarification stops or restarts the three-business-day response obligation.

Workflow setting: Clarification request does not automatically stop initial response deadline; require response within 3 business days, then place in Pending Clarification.

Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania

Pennsylvania's Right-to-Know Law says a written request should identify or describe the records with sufficient specificity to enable the agency to ascertain which records are being requested.

Pennsylvania's Office of Open Records specifically treats specificity as a major issue and provides a worksheet based on the court-developed balancing test. The normal agency response deadline is five business days; if the request is insufficiently specific, the agency can deny on that basis.

Workflow setting: If vague, issue denial or clarification request within 5 business days; no automatic tolling found; appeal risk if denied.

Dearborn, Michigan

Michigan FOIA requires a written request that describes the public record sufficiently to enable the public body to find it. The Michigan AG FOIA Handbook says if a request is denied because of insufficient description, the requester may rewrite the request with additional information or sue, with the issue being whether the description was sufficient.

Dearborn's public page requires a detailed list of requested documents/records and says responses are returned within 5–15 business days, with an extension letter if not ready in five business days.

Workflow setting: Valid-request clock starts only when request sufficiently describes records; allow clarification request or denial for insufficient description.

Boise, Idaho

Idaho's public records law imposes short response deadlines: Idaho residents generally receive approval or denial within three working days, with possible extension to 10 working days; nonresident deadlines are longer.

Boise's public-records page notes costs may apply if a request takes more than two hours, and Boise requires payment of the estimate before work begins. Boise State's policy, while not the City, is useful Idaho practice: requests must specifically describe the subject matter and records, include a specific date range, and be as specific as possible.

Workflow setting: No express vague-request tolling found; require specificity/date range fields; permit denial or incomplete status if not specific enough.

Miami, Florida

Florida is requester-friendly on broad requests. A Florida municipal policy quoting the Florida Public Records Handbook states agencies cannot deny a public records request merely because it is too broad or does not specifically identify the records requested. If it is not clear what records are sought, the office must contact the requester for clarification and should assist by explaining how the office keeps its records.

Miami's request page asks for date ranges, keywords/search terms, and departments because overly broad searches may produce thousands of documents.

Workflow setting: Do not auto-deny solely for breadth; require clarification-assist workflow; no fixed clock pause, but document good-faith clarification attempt.

Phoenix, Arizona

Arizona public records law requires public records to be open for inspection during office hours, but Arizona does not have the same kind of fixed response clock many states have. Arizona guidance emphasizes prompt access and the public body's duty to maintain records reasonably necessary to account for official activity.

I did not find a Phoenix-specific rule stating that clarification pauses or restarts a clock. For software purposes, Arizona should be modeled as a promptness/reasonableness jurisdiction rather than a fixed-deadline tolling jurisdiction.

Workflow setting: Pending Clarification = operational hold; no statutory toll/restart rule found; track total elapsed time for reasonableness.

San Francisco, California

California CPRA requires agencies to make records promptly available when a request reasonably describes identifiable records. Case law tempers this requirement because requesters may not know exact agency file names or structures.

California agencies generally have 10 days to determine whether they have disclosable responsive records, with a possible 14-day extension for unusual circumstances.

San Francisco adds its Sunshine Ordinance overlay. SFMTA says San Francisco agencies have 10 calendar days to respond and may extend by 14 calendar days in certain circumstances. San Francisco

training materials also warn that departments cannot refuse to respond to a request, and failure to respond can lead to discipline or legal action.

Workflow setting: Clarification allowed/encouraged, but do not treat as automatic clock stop; still require 10-day response or valid extension